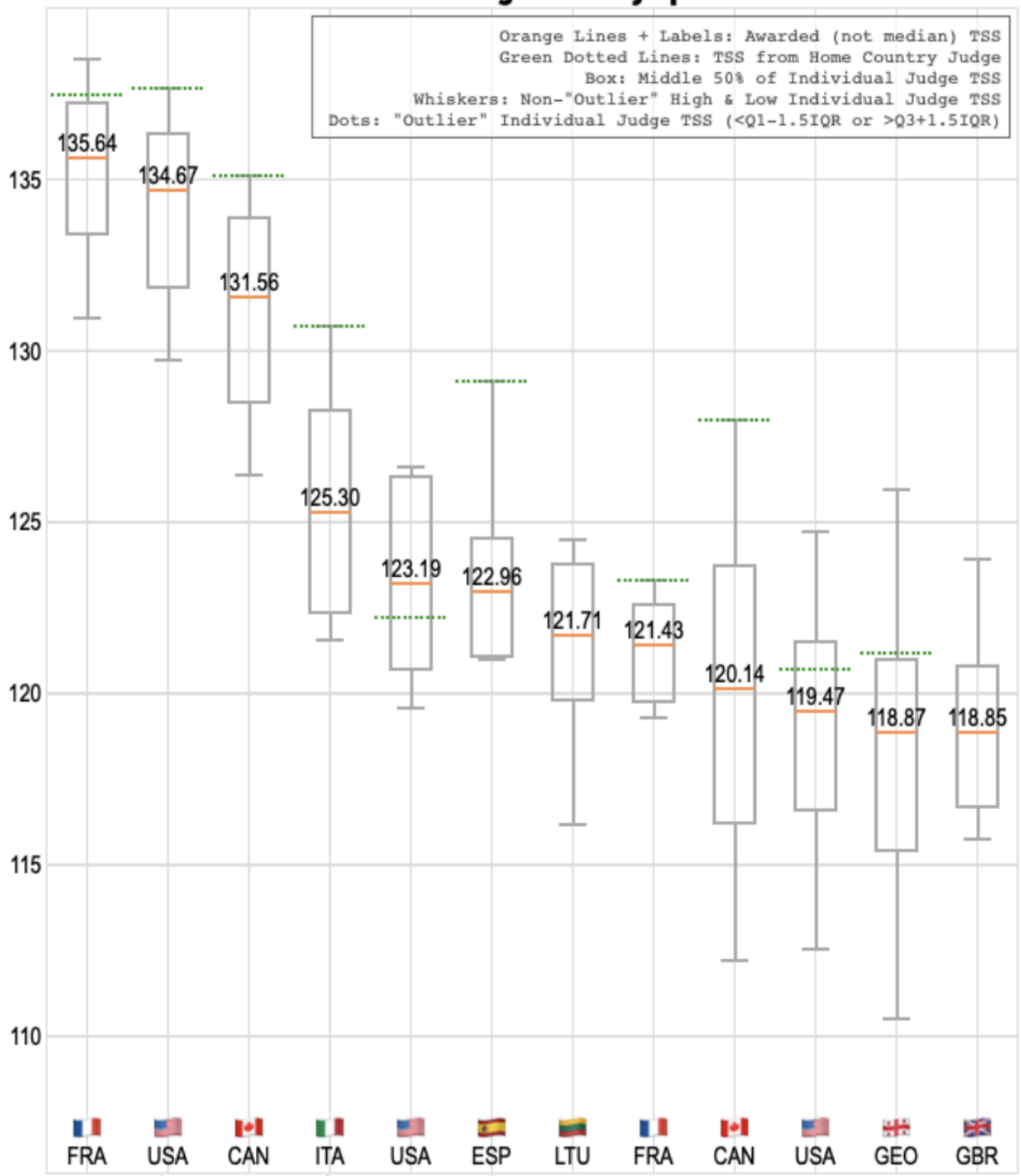
As the winter olympics are currently happening, as a competitive figure skater, I am following the figure skating events closely. Up until Friday (Ilia flopped), the most discussed portion of these winter olympic games has been the controversy surrounding the free dance results. Cizeron and F-Beaudry from France, who teamed up as the result of both facing allegations of physical, sexual, and mental abuse, upset the three-time reigning world champions Madison Chock and Evan Bates, despite showcasing a flawed skate. As a result, the online discourse has been flooded with analysis and critiques of the figure skating judging system and the bias within the scores that were awarded. One such graph that has been circulating points out the massive bias that the French judge had when scoring the French team. However, I believe that it indeed shows that this event was not as scandalous as popular media might suggest.

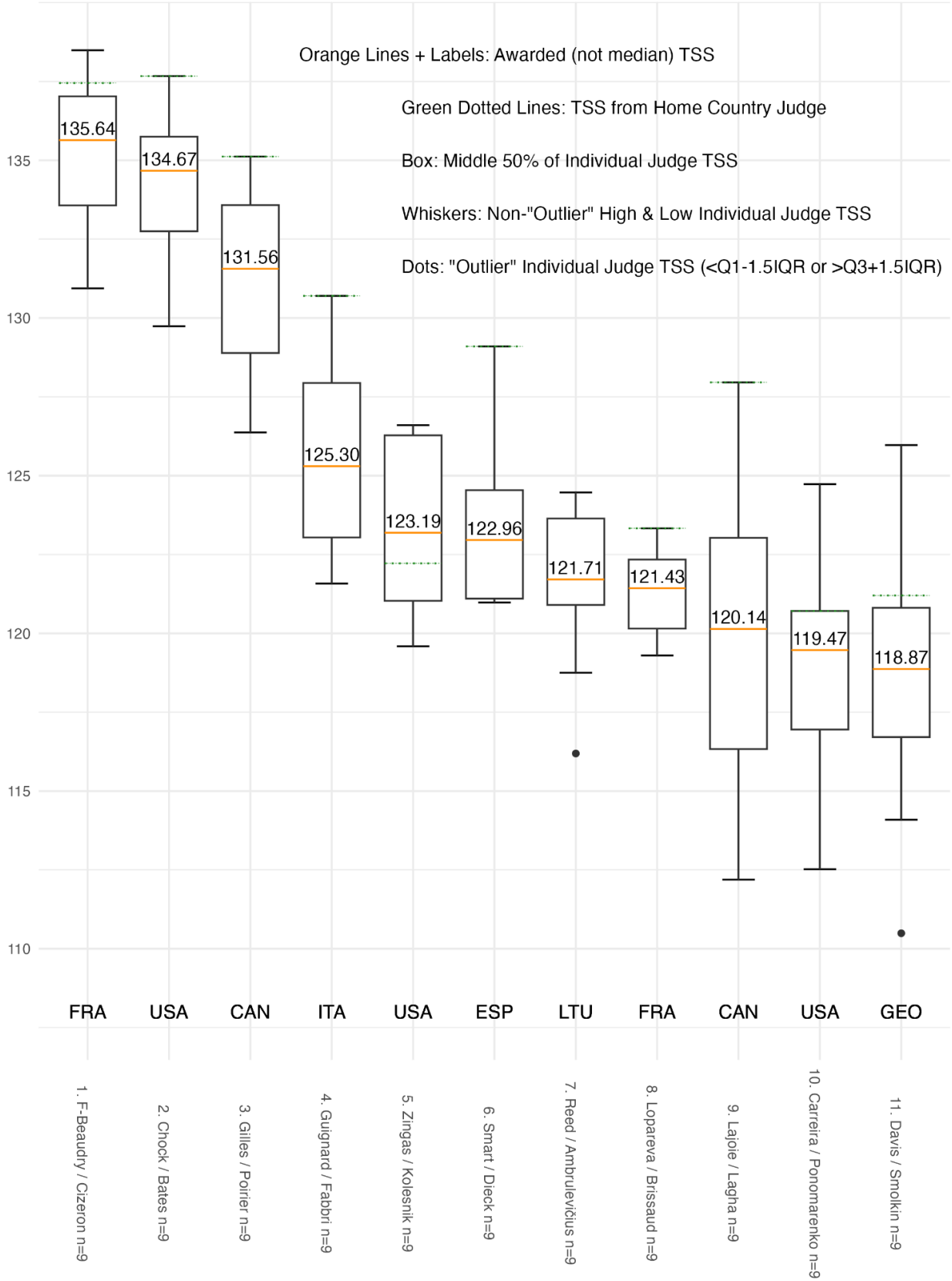
This is the graph:

2026 Olympic Winter Games Senior Free Dance
Individual Judge TSS Tally Spreads



I first recreate this plot in ggplot:

2026 Olympic Winter Games Senior Free Dance Individual Judge TSS Tally Spreads



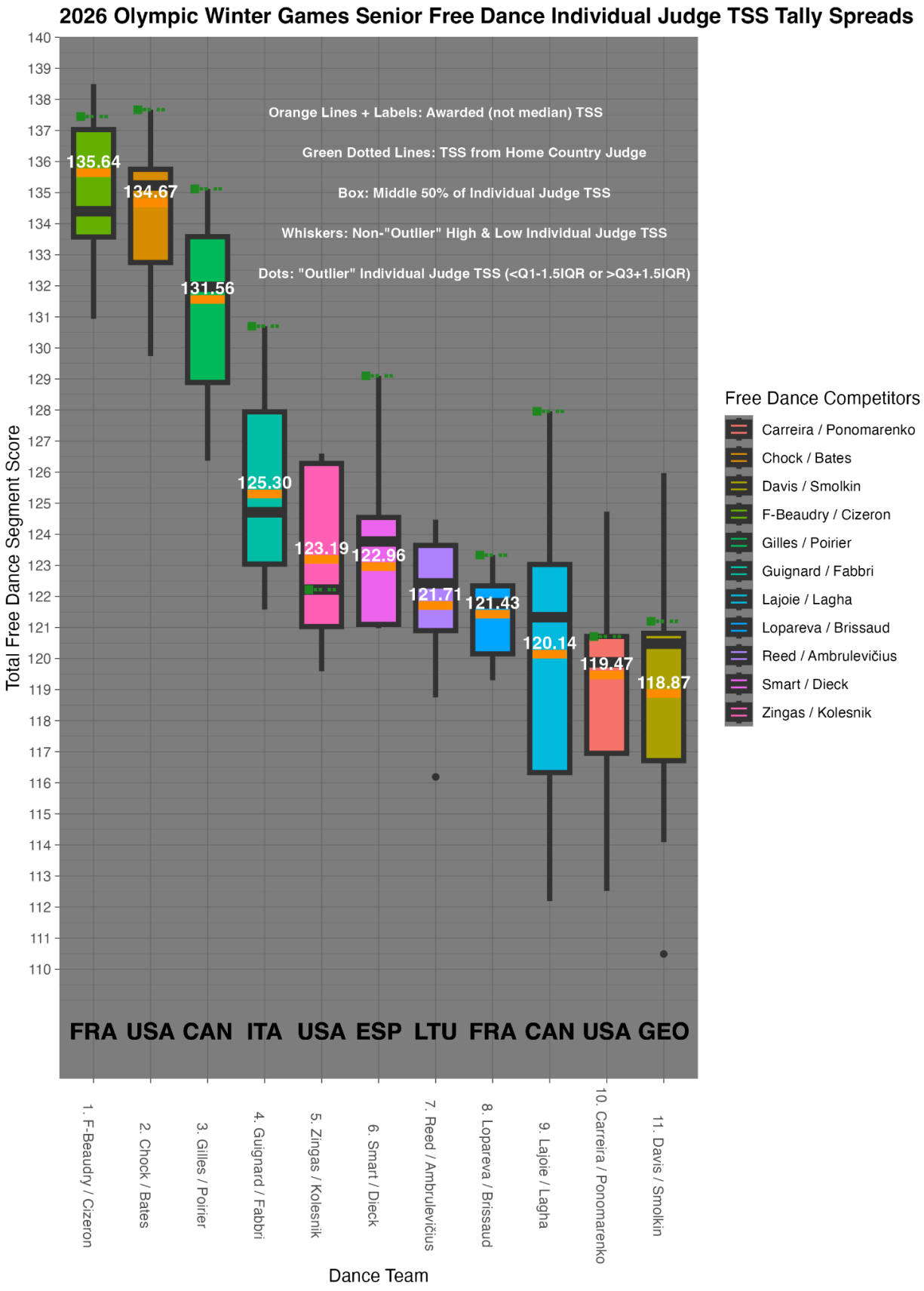
I would like to note that we can see very clearly that for almost every country (bar Canada's second team, and the Lithuanian team as there was no judge from Lithuania), the green line (home country's judge) is higher than the final awarded score (orange line).

I then increase the data-ink ratio twofold, decreasing the amount of non-data ink on the page:



As seen here, it is a bit hard now to parse, as there is only the slightest bit of non-data ink. I believe here that this graph is more useful to me, as I completely understand the figure skating scoring system already. However, as this scoring system is one that is tied up in rule after rules, and the tiniest of intricacies, I find that this simplified version may not be enough for the lay viewer.

On the other hand, I then add unnecessary non-data ink:


2026 Olympic Winter Games Senior Free Dance Individual Judge TSS Tally Spreads
Orange Lines + Labels: Awarded (not median) TSS
Green Dotted Lines: TSS from Home Country Judge
Box: Middle 50% of Individual Judge TSS
Whiskers: Non-"Outlier" High & Low Individual Judge TSS
Dots: "Outlier" Individual Judge TSS (<Q1-1.5IQR or >Q3+1.5IQR)
135.64
134.67
131.56
125.30
123.19
122.96
121.71
121.43
120.14
119.47
118.87
FRA USA CAN ITA USA ESP LTU FRA CAN USA GEO
Total Free Dance Segment Score
Dance Team
1. F-Beaudry / Cizeron
2. Chock / Bates
3. Gilles / Poirier
4. Guignard / Fabbri
5. Zingas / Kolesnik
6. Smart / Dieck
7. Reed / Ambrulevičius
8. Lopareva / Brissaud
9. Lajoie / Lagha
10. Carreira / Ponomarenko
11. Davis / Smolkin
Free Dance Competitors
Carreira / Ponomarenko
Chock / Bates
Davis / Smolkin
F-Beaudry / Cizeron
Gilles / Poirier
Guignard / Fabbri
Lajoie / Lagha
Lopareva / Brissaud
Reed / Ambrulevičius
Smart / Dieck
Zingas / Kolesnik

This graph is meant to achieve a data-ink ratio of 0.5. I have added a background, bolded the text, added duplicative axis, legend, and other titles. One such example of this is that we have both “Dance Team” and “Free Dance Competitors” as titles, when they are both providing the same exact information. This graph is hard to read, has very minimal visual appeal, and is unpleasant to look at. For this reason, I do not believe that having a data-ink ratio of 0.5 is necessarily the way to go in this case.

Overall, I thought that the original rendition of this graph was the most effective way of disseminating the information to the general public. However, for individuals such as myself who understand the intricacies of the sport, the 2x ratio plot suffices. There should be no reason to look at the last graph.